

Bola Sokunbi, a Nigerian financial expert who created the site [CleverGirlFinance.com](http://CleverGirlFinance.com), told me on my podcast: “Come age 65 or whatever your age that you want to retire is, there’s no one waiting for you with a bottle of champagne and a house on the beach and a million dollars saying, ‘Hey! Hey, girl! I built this for you. I saved this for you.’ You have to do it yourself.”

Before this year, saving for retirement was not something I ever considered. I just didn’t have the money, was too much in debt, and was too embarrassed to save in tiny amounts like fifty cents or a dollar. It didn’t seem like it mattered. Also, my parents never taught me about it. And as I’ve said, financial services are not marketed to people like me.

Research shows cisgender women outlive cisgender men by almost a decade. Women may need retirement money for longer, but we don’t make as much because of the wage and investment gaps. In general, men die younger than women do AND with more money. If a financial product is marketed to anyone other than cis men, it’s usually not done well: “They just slap pink on it and say ‘Here! Finance for women!’” Sokunbi said. (To counter this, check out Sallie Krawcheck’s company Ellevest, a company created to help women specifically to invest, to combat the investment gap. Krawcheck has mocked the Wall Street symbol as being a literal bull. Not very inviting.)

In her eye-opening book, *Pound Foolish*, Helaine Olen takes a questionnaire to see how well she’d do at saving for retirement. One of the questions was a metaphor regarding college basketball, and she got it wrong. (Obviously MANY women and nonbinary people know about sports. Olen, who grew up in a time when women were not encouraged to participate in sports, just doesn’t.) The test told her she’d be bad at odds and therefore bad at investing. She argued that all it proved was she didn’t know anything about sports and that retirement information is primarily aimed at men (who typically might recognize sports metaphors). (Some men.) (Look. You get it.)

The only people who have access to my SEP IRA are me and my accountant, Dan. I think of any money I put in there as nonexistent. It is gone once I give it to him. If you’re able, you can set it up to have some money automatically deposited into a retirement fund each month, and then you’ll never think about